The Sādhana Called the Six Limbs

Ṣaḍaṅgasādhana · Toh 1239 · Derge Tengyur
ཡན་ལག་དྲུག་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའི་སྒྲུབ་ཐབས

The Sādhana Called the Six Limbs, known in Sanskrit as the Ṣaḍaṅga Sādhana and in Tibetan as Yenlak Drukpa Zhejawé Druptap, is a short verse manual of tantric practice centered on Hevajra, the eight-faced, sixteen-armed deity who is lord of a maṇḍala of eight goddesses. Drawing on the Hevajra Tantra and the lineage of the master Ḍombī, it guides the practitioner through preliminary worship, the generation of the celestial palace and the deity in union with Nairātmyā, and the six limbs of the practice: vajra passion, meditation on the palace, empowerment, tasting nectar, offering and praise, before explaining the symbolism of the deity's form and closing with mantras and a torma offering. Its colophon attributes it to the master Ajitacandra and records its translation into Tibetan by the Indian preceptor Ratnaśrījñāna and the monk Shakya Yeshé. It is Toh 1239 in the Tengyur, where it belongs among the tantra commentaries as one of the sādhanas of the Hevajra cycle.

In the language of India: ṣaḍaṃga sādhanaṃ nāma. In the language of Tibet: The Sādhana Called the Six Limbs.

Homage to Hevajra.

Abiding in the illusory maṇḍala, like the moon in water, lord of the eight goddesses,
Hevajra, true embodiment gathering the liberations, emanating faces, feet and hands of suchness,
delighting to work for sentient beings in the delightful place at the heart of the māras,
like a dancer, like space, acting in fierce pride and protecting beings,
like the emanation body of the first buddha,
the one vehicle that ferries across the river of birth:
to the guru I always bow with reverence.

From the great Hevajra Tantra, which is like an ocean,
by the sequence received from the venerable Ḍombī,
I shall compose this sādhana of Śrī Hevajra,
a probe for the veil of ignorance that is like darkness.

With this mind set on accomplishment,
at night, in one's own house,
in a charnel ground, or on a riverbank,
one should meditate without fear.

At the heart, a lotus and a sun;
meditate distinctly on the image arising from hūṃ.
Having worshipped the vajra guru,
for the complete purity of the seven branches,
the eight goddesses, Gaurī and the rest,
should send forth offerings in full.

I confess the evil I have done,
and restrain myself from doing it again;
I rejoice in merit,
and I dedicate it all completely.
Going for refuge to the Jewels,
generating the supreme mind of awakening,
abiding on the path, and offering
myself as well for the sake of others,
and receiving permission: then meditate
on the four abodes of Brahmā.
First, meditate on loving-kindness;
second, on the particulars of compassion;
third, meditate on joy;
and last of all, equanimity.

Then again, meditate on the awakening of emptiness
and recite this:
oṃ śūnyatā jñāna vajra svabhāva va ātmako'haṃ.

From emptiness, a lotus, and what arises from raṃ;
upon the hūṃ itself, meditate on a crossed vajra.
To dispel the māras of beings,
emanate brightly from the hūṃ.
oṃ rakṣa rakṣa hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ svāhā.
This syllable is recited.
From this, meditate as well
on the surrounding vajra tent and the canopy.

On the vajra ground, the expanse of space,
are the maṇḍalas arising from yaṃ raṃ vaṃ laṃ.
From bhrūṃ, upon the wheel, oneself:
meditate on the one born of the intermediate state.
These are the four maṇḍalas of the elements;
this wheel is the fifth.
Becoming one, they turn
into the celestial palace of the buddhas:
four-sided, with four gates,
adorned with four porticoes,
endowed with nets and half-nets,
beautifully adorned with eight pillars.
The lights of the eight goddesses,
by their clarity, are its friezes.
Within it is drawn a lotus
of eight petals and a single garland;
abiding on the disc of the sun,
it is adorned with the four māras.
oṃ sarva tathāgata alānīya vajra svabhāva ātmako'ho.

The palace of the buddhas is complete in detail.
Meditating on the five aspects:
the moon is mirror-like wisdom;
the seven-horsed sun is equality;
the seeds and hand emblems of the deity
are said to be discernment;
all are earnestly to be made one;
the complete image is the dharmadhātu.

Meditate on āli as the moon;
kāli is the seven-horsed sun.
Between the two, oṃ and hūṃ;
these two become a vajra and a curved knife.
Moon, sun, seeds and hand emblems:
all of these become one,
not separate, like water and milk.
Such is the meditation on the vajra:
eight faces and sixteen arms,
terrifying, with four legs,

the hero with a garland of skulls,
embraced at the neck by Nairātmyā,
the deity who bears the five mudrās,
with the color and light of a moonstone.
The root face has the color of the body;
of the faces on the left, red, white and the others.
Elephant, horse, donkey, ox, camel,
man, lion, and cat:
these are in the eight skull cups on the right,
to be known in order, beginning with the elephant.
Earth, the Water-Dweller (Varuṇa), Wind,
the Fire God, then the Illuminator (the Sun),
then Antaka and Dhanada (Kubera):
these are in the eight skull cups on the left.
The goddess has one face and two arms;
she is black, with tawny hair bristling upward;
she holds a curved knife, a skull cup and a khaṭvāṅga,
and wears a tiger-skin skirt.

oṃ padma sukhādhara mahārāga sukhanda da catur ānanda bhaga viśva hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ karyaṃ kuruṣva me. oṃ vajra mahādveṣa catur ānanda dāyaka khaga mukhaikaraso nātha hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ karyaṃ kuruṣva me. oṃ sarva tathāgata anurāgaṇa vajra svabhāva ātmako'haṃ.

First imagine the male, and then
emanate the circle of ḍākinīs.
Through vajra passion,
the semen of the Victors follows,
and becomes eight seeds.
That drop of the Tathāgatas:
gaṃ caṃ vaṃ ghaṃ vaṃ saṃ laṃ ḍaṃ,
the seeds of the goddesses, is sent forth.
Gaurī in Indra's quarter, Caurī in Yama's,
Vetālī in the abode of the Lord of Waters (Varuṇa),
Ghasmarī with the Big-Bellied One (Kubera),
and likewise Pukkasī with Īśāna,
Śavarī in the corner of the Fire-Eater (Agni),
Caṇḍālī abiding with Nairṛti,

and Ḍombī here in the abode of the Wind:
the circle of goddesses is complete.
The two ho abiding in the center
are the syllables of body, speech and mind;
this is the name of the being of the intermediate state.
Meditate on it in the lotus of the goddess.
The intermediate being entering into union
is recollected in the form of semen.
Urged on by the goddesses of the quarters,
one should then be urged with songs:

Arise, Unsurpassed One, with a mind of compassion!
Protect me, Pukkasī!
Abandoning the nature of emptiness,
unite with me in the great bliss I desire.
If you do not remain, I shall die;
so abandon the very nature of emptiness,
and for Śavarī's fruit to be accomplished,
O Hevajra, arise!
Lord of desire, aspiring for the world's sake,
why do you remain in the state of emptiness?
If you do not remain, the quarters cannot bear it.
I, Caṇḍālī, make this supplication.
I, Ḍombī, with my mind bewildered,
seek your heart, so do not cut off
the stream of your compassion:
arise like a magical illusion!

These are the songs of urging.
Through the urging, one recollects
the aspiration for awakening made in the past.

Rising up from the form of semen,
oṃ and hūṃ, the two, are the great vajra.
He has eight faces and four legs,
and is adorned with sixteen arms.
Trampling the four māras all alike,
a dancer in the half-cross-legged posture,
he wears a garland of heads as a necklace

and bears a crossed vajra on his crown.
The root face is deep black,
the right one like a white water lily,
the left one red, great and terrifying,
and the remaining faces are like bees.
He is rich with twenty-four eyes,
and gives bliss to Nairātmyā.

Elephant, horse, donkey, ox, camel,
man, lion, and cat:
these are the eight skull cups on the right,
to be known in order, beginning with the elephant.
Earth, the Water-Dweller (Varuṇa), Wind,
Fire, the Moon, then the Illuminator (the Sun),
then Antaka and Dhanada (Kubera):
these are in the eight skull cups on the left.

Gaurī is black in color;
Caurī is like madder;
Vetālī has the color of refined gold;
Ghasmarī is like emerald;
Pukkasī is sapphire blue;
Śavarī has the light of a moonstone;
Caṇḍālī is sky blue;
Ḍombī is held to be of many colors.

Gaurī has a curved knife in her right hand,
and in her left, likewise, a fish.
Caurī has a hand drum in her right,
and in her left, likewise, a pig.
Vetālī has a turtle in her right;
her left hand holds a skull cup.
The Devourer, Ghasmarī, has a snake in her right;
her left hand holds a skull cup.
Pukkasī has a lion in her right,
and in her left hand holds an axe.
Śavarī has a monk in her right;
in her left, know that she holds a monk's ringing staff.
Caṇḍālī has a wheel in her right,

and in her left, likewise, a skull cup.
Ḍombī has a vajra in her right,
and in her left, likewise, the threatening gesture.
They stand in the dance of the half-cross-legged posture.
Know that Gaurī and the rest have two arms,
three eyes, and hair standing upward,
beautiful with the five mudrās.
Brahmā, Indra, Upendra (Viṣṇu), Rudra,
Yama, the Lord of Wealth (Kubera),
Nairṛti, and Vemacitrin
are the seats of Gaurī and the rest.

All of these, through this vajra,
their own mantra syllables complete,
having become mudrās and hand emblems:
then meditate on the wisdom at the heart.
At one's own heart, on lotus and sun, a hūṃ and a vajra:
the heart where the hūṃ, the wisdom being, dwells.
The hūṃ and vajra resting on lotus and sun,
and the hūṃ as wisdom, are then imagined.
Dissolving evenly into the circle of commitment,
the great circle of wisdom blazes.
The buddhas and bodhisattvas
are evoked, and many others as well.
With this command, ja hūṃ vaṃ hoḥ,
by these four, Gaurī and the rest,
they are drawn in, made to enter,
bound, and made to rejoice.

For the eyes and the rest, delusion and the rest,
imagine the three vajras at the three places.
At the two eyes, Mohavajrī;
at the two ears, Dveṣavajrī;
at the nose, the one called Mātsaryavajrī;
at the mouth, Rāgavajrī;
at the body, Īrṣyāvajrī;
at the mind, Nairātmyayoginī.
Each is generated from the first letter of her name,

with two arms and one lovely face,
holding curved knife and skull cup in her hands,
of many colors, on a corpse seat.
At the places of body, speech and mind,
oṃ āḥ hū is the mantra for this.
From this, meditate on the sky-goers and earth-goers
as dwelling beneath the feet.
The vajra of body, speech and mind
and the yoginīs are the three families in actuality.

Emanate specially the seed at one's own heart;
with light rays in the form of hooks,
invite the buddhas and truly worship them.
Then the empowerment is requested:
"Protectors, all you tathāgatas,
confer empowerment upon me!"
Then these tathāgatas,
having taken the form of Heruka,
hold in their own hands vases
filled with the water of the five nectars,
and pour it, conferring empowerment. At the end,
Akṣobhya is the seal of the root deity;
he is also the seal
of Gaurī and of Pukkasī.
The Buddha, Ratnasambhava and Amitābha
seal the latter six, two by two in order.
oṃ sarva tathāgata abhiṣekata vajra svabhāva ātmako'haṃ.

Blowing, blazing, the skull cup, the five hooks, and tasting the flavor of the nectar that has become the five seeds: imagining a vajra the size of a barley grain; this is according to the Glorious Hevajra Tantra. oṃ sarva tathāgata amṛta svadana vajra svabhāva ātmako'haṃ.

The varied wisdom offerings and the rest,
the offerings of these eight goddesses,
are sent forth, and the Lord of the Circle
is first worshipped by the one who is the circle's very self.
oṃ sarva tathāgata pūja vajra svabhāva ātmako'haṃ.

Then those yoginīs
praise the chief of the circle:
"You are encircled by the yoginīs;
by your own mind your intent is fulfilled.
You who accomplish all of saṃsāra, the moving and the unmoving,
with a heart of compassion, a mind that through relative illusion
brings sentient beings to the accomplishment of awakening:
delighted Śrī Heruka Vajra, we praise you!"
oṃ sarva tathāgata stuti vajra svabhāva ātmako'haṃ.

Vajra passion,
meditation on the buddhas' palace in detail,
empowerment, tasting the nectar,
offering and praise: these are the six limbs.
Whatever yogin meditates on the six limbs
swiftly obtains accomplishment.
The palace is the Buddha Vairocana;
the empowerment, the Tathāgata Akṣobhya;
tasting the nectar, Amitābha;
praise, the glorious Ratnasambhava;
offering, Amogha, the true offering;
passion is Vajrasattva.

As for the generation through the six limbs,
by which this accomplishment draws near:
first one sees what is like clouds;
second, what is like smoke;
third, the form of lightning;
fourth, a blazing lamp;
fifth, everything appearing,
like a cloudless sky.
Afterwards it is like the form of an illusion:
appearances as in a dream, instant by instant.
By caṇḍālī blazing at the navel,
the five tathāgatas are burned,
and Locanā and the others are burned as well;
being burned, the hare-marked moon flows from haṃ.

Whatever yogin is unable to meditate
should recollect the pure meaning:

the red eyes are compassion;
the black limbs, the mind of loving-kindness;
the four means of gathering
are said to be the four legs;
the eight faces are the liberations;
the sixteen arms are the emptinesses;
the five mudrās are the buddhas;
the wrathful one is the tamer of the wicked;
the three eyes are the three bodies;
the bones are the Four Truths.

Form is Vajrā;
feeling, Secret Gaurī;
likewise the aggregate of perception is Vārī;
formations, Vajraḍākinī;
and consciousness is Nairātmyā.
Ultimately there are no aggregates.
That becomes the six limbs.

For the six sense sources, purified:
Dveṣavajrī is Vajrā;
the vajra rasanā is the flowing one,
and so likewise is Īrṣyāvajrī;
Mohavajrī, too,
is Vajraḍākinī;
Mātsaryavajrī is Secret Gaurī;
in the mind is Nairātmyayoginī.

Earth is declared to be Pukkasī;
the waters are called Śavarī;
heat is to be known as Caṇḍālī;
wind is proclaimed to be Ḍombī.
Form is rightly explained as Gaurī;
sound is explained as Caurī;
each smell is Vetālī;
the mode of taste is the Devourer, Ghasmarī;
the tangible is called the Earth-Goer;
the element of phenomena is the Sky-Goer.

Beginning with Earth and ending with Dhanada (Kubera),
all riches and lands are accomplished.
Holding the elephant and the rest
brings the complete pacifying of disease:
cough, breath, and likewise madness,
vomiting blood, leprosy, birjika,
spleen and liver; their own forms
are declared to be the elephant and the rest.
From ni raṃ su or from another,
perform the meditation and the recitation of the mantra.

oṃ aṣṭānanāya viṃgordhakeśavartmane caturviṃśati netrāya śoḍaśabhujāya kṛṣṇajīmūtavapuṣe kapālamālānekādhāriṇe ātmātakrūracittāya ardhendudaṃṣṭṛṇe māraya māraya kāraya kāraya garjjaya garjjaya tarjjaya tarjjaya śoṣaya śoṣaya saptasāgarāna bandha bandha nāgāṣṭakān gṛhṇa gṛhṇa sarvaśatrūṃ ha hā hi hī hu hū he hai ho hau haṃ haḥ phaṭ svāhā.

To pacify all obstacles completely,
one should give the torma continually.
oṃ indaṃ jama jala jakkha bhūta vahni vā u rākkha canda sujja mada vappa tala pātāle aṣṭa sappa svāhā idaṃ valiṃ bhuṃja jiṃgha phulla dhūppa māṃsa piṃga ambha sappa kajja sāda khanti khuṇi pheṭa gāda oṃ akāro mukhaṃ sarvadharmmāṇāṃ ādyanutpannatvāt oṃ āḥ hūṃ phaṭ svāhā.

The many lotuses of the goddess tantra
the guru Śānti opened with the light of the sun;
Ajitacandra drank their honey with relish,
and this sādhana is that honey brought forth again.
By the power of the Glorious One's compassion I have made this sādhana.
Whatever merit comes from my labor on it,
may the vehicle thereby gained, which ferries across the ocean of birth,
become the cause of freeing beings.

The Sādhana Called the Six Limbs, composed by the master Ajitacandra, is complete.

As the holy guru commanded,
the monk Shakya Yeshé
translated this Six-Limbed Sādhana
as best he could, for Shakya Könchok and Dakmé
and for the sake of all yoginīs.

Whatever merit there is, may they swiftly attain Hevajra!

It was translated by the Indian preceptor Ratnaśrījñāna and the monk Shakya Yeshé.

Translator's Notes

• "I always bow" reads □□□□□ for the written □□□□□□ ("conception"), which makes little sense in the homage. The list of guardians in the left skull cups names seven (Earth, Varuṇa, Wind, Agni, Sun, Antaka, Dhanada) for eight cups; it is translated as it stands. "The quarters cannot bear it" renders the obscure □□□□□□□□□□□□□ literally.
• "The Buddha, Ratnasambhava and Amitābha" renders the abbreviated □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□; "the Buddha" here probably stands for Vairocana. Amogha (□□□□□□□) is Amoghasiddhi. □□□□□□□, "the Devourer", is taken as Ghasmarī, who stands in this position in the list.
• The line "the vajra rasanā is the flowing one" renders the obscure □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ literally; it may be a corrupt form of a goddess's name (perhaps Vārī, "the flowing one"). birjika is a disease name left in its Sanskrit form, and ni raṃ su is unclear and left as written. Ajitacandra is reconstructed from □□□□□□□□□□□. In the colophon verse, Shakya Könchok and Dakmé are taken as two dedicatees; □□□□□□□ could also be part of a single name.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.